

Week 2: A House Divided/Bleeding Kansas

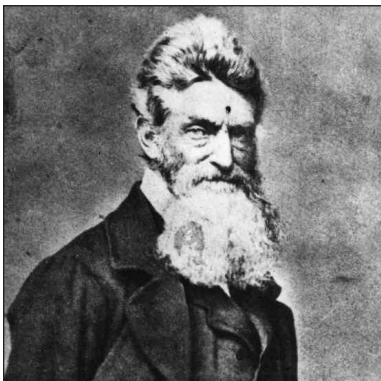
Questions

1. Consider the growing sectional crisis from both points of view. As a Southerner, explain how the North is conspiring to deprive you of your liberties. And, as a Northerner, list the ways in which the Southern slave power is plotting the triumph of slave over free labor. Do you see any way to preserve the Union?

2. Civil War historian Don Fehrenbacher writes, "Southern attitudes throughout the Kansas controversy demonstrate the intensely reactive nature of southern sectionalism. That is, the South did not so much respond to the Kansas-Nebraska issue itself as react to the northern response to the issue..." Expand on his remark, using material from your reading and lectures in your answer.

Key Terms

- Popular Sovereignty
- Kansas-Nebraska Act
- Caning of Charles Sumner
- Stephen A. Douglas
- Abraham Lincoln
- John Brown
- Republican Party
- Cooper Union Address
- Dred Scott decision



John Brown thought of himself as a modern-day Moses, and grew his beard out accordingly.

Comments on Sectional Politics in the 1850's



In thinking of America, I sometimes find myself admiring her bright blue sky, her grand old woods her fertile fields, her beautiful rivers, her mighty lakes and star-crowned mountains. But my rapture is soon checked when I remember that all is cursed with the infernal spirit of slave-holding and wrong; When I remember that with the waters of her noblest rivers, the tears of my brethren are borne to the ocean, disregarded and forgotten...I am filled with unutterable loathing.

- Frederick Douglass in a letter to William Lloyd Garrison, January 1, 1846

We warn you that the dearest interest of freedom and the Union are in imminent peril. Demagogues may tell you that the Union can be maintained only by submitting to the demands of slavery. We tell you that the Union can only be maintained by the full recognition of the just claims of freedom and man. The Union was formed to establish justice and secure the blessings of liberty. When it fails to accomplish these ends it will be worthless, and when it becomes worthless it cannot long endure.

- Northern Democrats Protest the Kansas Nebraska Act, January 19, 1854



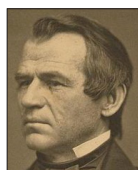
The Senator from South Carolina has read many books of chivalry, and believes himself a chivalrous knight, with sentiments of honor and courage. Of course he has chosen a mistress to whom he has made his vows, and who, though ugly to others, is always lovely to him—though polluted in the sight of the world, is chaste in his sight: I mean the harlot Slavery...The asserted rights of slavery, which shock equality of all kinds, are cloaked by a fantastic claim of equality. If the Slave States cannot enjoy what, in mockery of the great fathers of the Republic, he misnames Equality under the Constitution—in other words, the full power in the National Territories to compel fellow-men to unpaid toil, to separate husband and wife, and to sell little children at the auction-block—then, Sir, the chivalric Senator will conduct the State of South Carolina out of the Union! Heroic Knight! Exalted Senator! A second Moses come for a second exodus!

- Mass. Senator Charles Sumner on "The Crime Against Kansas," May 20, 1856



Hitherto, the two systems have existed in different states, but side by side within the American Union. This has happened because the Union is a confederation of states. But in another aspect the United States constitute only one nation. Increase of population, which is filling the states out to their very borders, together with a new and extended net-work of railroads and other avenues, and an internal commerce which daily becomes more intimate, is rapidly bringing the states into a higher and more perfect social unity or consolidation. Thus, these antagonistic systems are continually coming into closer contact, and collision results. Shall I tell you what this collision means? They who think that it is accidental, unnecessary, the work of interested or fanatical agitators, and therefore ephemeral, mistake the case altogether. It is an irrepressible conflict between opposing and enduring forces, and it means that the United States must and will, sooner or later, become either entirely a slaveholding nation, or entirely a free-labor nation.

- N.Y. Senator William H. Seward, October 25, 1858



Instead of there being a conflict, an irrepressible conflict, between slave labor and free labor, I say the argument is clear and conclusive that the one mutually benefits the other; that slave labor is a great help and aid to free labor, as well as free labor to slave labor. Where does the northern man go, to a very great extent, with his manufactured articles? He goes to the South for a market, or the southern merchant goes to the North and buys them...

- Tenn. Senator Andrew Johnson, in response to Seward, December 1858

I, John Brown, am now quite certain that the crimes of this guilty land will never be purged away but with Blood.

- John Brown, in a note delivered just before he was hanged, December 2, 1859